

The Tower

I was born in the Tower.

Not in a hospital. Not in a house on a quiet street with a yard and a mailbox and neighbors who wave. In the Tower. Specifically, in the small medical room on Floor 47, under fluorescent lights that hummed at a frequency that has followed me into every dream I've ever had. My mother sometimes jokes that I came out already knowing how to count floors. I've never found it funny, but I've never told her that.

The Tower is seventy floors tall. At least, that's what they tell us. I've counted the windows from the inside, and the numbers match. What they don't tell us, what no one seems to want to talk about, is what's below Floor 1. Because there's something below Floor 1. You can feel it in the elevator, a faint vibration in the soles of your feet when the car descends and slows and *keeps going* for just a second too long before the doors open to the lobby. I've felt it since I was four years old, and I've never mentioned it to anyone. It seemed like the kind of thing that, once said aloud, couldn't be unsaid.

We live on Floor 47, my family. My mother, Sera, tends the hydroponic gardens on Floor 52. She comes home smelling of damp soil and synthetic nutrients, her fingernails permanently stained a faint greenish brown that never fully washes out. She is kind and careful and laughs easily, and she has never once looked out a window for longer than a few seconds. My father, Dov, maintains the ventilation systems, the great wheezing lungs of the building that push recycled air from floor to floor. He is quieter than my mother, more watchful. He taught me how to play chess when I was six. He always lets me win until I'm too good to need it, and then he doesn't anymore. He never talks about the ventilation shafts. Not what he sees in them, not where they go. When I was small, I thought that was just professional discretion. I'm not so sure anymore.

The air in the Tower has a smell. Everyone knows it but no one names it, that faint metallic tang, like old coins held in a warm fist, mixed with the mineral breath of damp concrete. In the gardens it softens, becomes something almost earthy. Everywhere else it persists, constant and slightly wrong, like the smell of a room where something happened a long time ago and was very thoroughly cleaned.

I went to school on Floor 43. Math, technical skills, systems thinking. Our teacher was a tall woman named Instructor Voss who wore her gray hair pulled back so tightly it seemed to hold her entire expression in place, a permanent composed neutrality, except for her eyes, which were very sharp and very still. She was an excellent teacher. She taught us everything we needed to know to maintain the Tower, to understand the Tower, to be useful to the Tower. History, she taught differently. History was short. The world had ended, or near enough, and the Tower had saved whoever was worth saving. There wasn't much more to say about it.

Every lesson, every unit, every subject eventually curved back to the same conclusion, delivered in the same flat instructional tone:

The Tower is safety. The Tower is life. There is nothing else.

We repeated it at the start of morning assembly, the whole floor murmuring it together like a prayer. I used to mouth it without thinking, the way you stop hearing a song that plays every day. Then one day, I was maybe twelve, I actually listened to what I was saying. *There is nothing else. Not there is nothing better. Not there is nowhere safer.* Nothing else. A flat erasure. As though the entire world outside had been not destroyed but simply deleted, like an error corrected.

That was the day I started paying attention.

I found the books by accident.

The library on Floor 43 was rarely used, which itself should have meant something to me at the time. It was stocked with technical manuals, approved texts, and rows of gray-spined reference volumes that all seemed to be about the Tower's systems in one way or another. I went there sometimes to be alone, which was its own kind of reading. One afternoon, doing nothing in particular, I pressed my palm flat against the far wall and felt it, a slight give, a pocket of air behind the panel. The kind of thing you'd miss if you weren't being aimless and unhurried about it.

Behind the panel there were eleven books. I counted them. They were old in a way that felt almost sacred, pages gone soft at the edges, spines cracked and faded, the smell of them something I had no word for at the time. I know the word now: *old*. The simple, physical smell of time accumulated in paper. I had never encountered it before.

I read them over the following two years, a few pages at a time, in the library during my free periods. I didn't tell anyone. I'm not sure I could have explained why, only that some instinct, deeply seated and very certain, told me not to.

The books described a world. Not a dead one, not a poisoned one, not the wasteland we'd been taught. A world with mountains that held snow year-round, with rivers so cold they made your hands ache, with forests so dense that sunlight came through the canopy in individual beams like pillars of something almost solid. The books had photographs in some cases, images that had faded toward yellow and brown but were still unmistakably *outside*. Grasslands. Coastlines. A sky the color of a bruise just before it heals, streaked with orange and rose.

There were animals I had no names for. Long-legged things that moved across plains with an ease that looked effortless, the way water looks effortless. Small clever-faced creatures peering from hollow logs. Something enormous and gray with a face that seemed ancient in a way human faces never are.

I sat with those photographs for a long time.

The question wasn't whether these things had existed. I was old enough, and I'd read enough, to understand that photographs aren't invented. The question was *when*. The teachers said the world had ended before the Tower was built. If that was true, these

photographs were history, beautiful and gone, irrelevant except as evidence of what we'd lost. But the books had no clear dates. And some of the photographs had a quality to them, a sharpness, a particular quality of light, that didn't feel ancient. That felt recent in a way I couldn't prove and couldn't shake.

I put them back behind the panel each time. I never mentioned them. I'm telling you now and I still feel the specific weight of that choice pressing behind my ribs.

The windows trouble me.

I know that sounds strange. Windows are supposed to be the point of a tall building, the view, the light, the connection to the outside. But the windows in the Tower don't give you any of those things. Every pane is sealed against a fog so thick and dark it reads less as weather and more as *material*, something that presses against the glass rather than drifting past it. On very clear days, or what passes for clear days here, you can sometimes make out a faint gray-white luminance through the murk, a suggestion that somewhere beyond all of it there might be a sky. Most days there's nothing. Just the dark. Just the fog moving in long slow currents against the outside of the glass, almost like something breathing.

And the rain. There is always rain. Not the sudden, dramatic kind I'd read about in the books, crashing summer storms and hailstones and the immediate brightening of the air after. This rain is different. It doesn't fall so much as *accumulate*, a constant fine mist that beads on the exterior and runs in thin rivulets down the pane in patterns that change daily but never stop. I've spent hours watching those patterns. They are not random. I don't know what they are, but they're not random.

Once, when I was about nine, I asked my father if the rain ever stopped.

He was sitting in his chair by the window, reading the maintenance logs he always brought home, and he looked up at me in a way I've thought about many times since. Not annoyed. Not dismissive. Something closer to, careful. Like a man choosing a step on uncertain ice.

"Focus on your future, Ren," he said.

That was all. He went back to his logs. I went to bed.

I have focused on my future. I think about it all the time. What I can't stop thinking is that my future is inside this building, and my father, who knows its walls and ducts and hidden passages better than almost anyone, told me to focus on it, and not on the rain. As though those were two separate things. As though the outside world and my future existed in separate categories that would never intersect.

He's never said anything like that since. But I've never forgotten the way he looked at me, just before the words came. Like the words themselves were a choice. Like there were other words, different words, sitting right behind them, and he'd decided against them.

The lower floors are forbidden below Floor 25.

This is not a rumor or a vague policy, there are steel barriers at every stairwell access below that threshold, and elevators simply don't show buttons for the floors beneath it. The buttons for 1 through 24 are there on the panel, present but dark, unlit, unresponsive. I've pressed them. Everyone has pressed them, I think, at least once. They don't give. They don't light up. They sit there like scars.

The men who guard the stairwells wear long dark coats and masks that cover the entire face, smooth, featureless, the same gray-white as the fog outside the windows. Their eyes are visible through narrow lenses, and the lenses catch the emergency lighting in the corridors and reflect it back as a dull, flat red. Not a bright red. Not the red of alarm. Something cooler. The red of something that has been glowing a very long time.

I passed one of them up close once, three years ago. I was seventeen, cutting through the stairwell between Floors 28 and 27 because the elevator was crowded and I was late. He was standing at the landing below, not pacing, not leaning, just standing, hands at his sides, facing the lower door. I came down the stairs quickly and he didn't turn at the sound of my footsteps, which was strange, because I wasn't quiet. And then, as I passed, he tilted his head.

Not toward me. Not the reflex of someone registering a presence nearby. He tilted it back and slightly to the side, the slow inclination of someone hearing something very faint from a great distance, straining to resolve it. I stopped moving without meaning to. I stood on that landing for two or three seconds, completely still, watching the back of his masked head.

Then he straightened. He didn't turn. He didn't speak. He went back to facing the door.

I went the rest of the way down at a run, heart knocking stupidly against the inside of my chest, telling myself it meant nothing. People have odd habits. Guards stand in strange ways. It meant nothing.

But I keep coming back to the direction he was listening in.

Downward.

At night, the Tower gets quiet in a way that doesn't feel like silence. True silence is absence, an emptiness of sound. What happens here after midnight is something different. It's a *low* quiet. A subsidence. As though the building itself is attending to something, holding its collective breath. I've lain awake in it many times, and every time I notice the same thing: the ventilation hum changes pitch slightly, drops a register, takes on a faintness that makes the air feel heavier, closer. My father says it's just the system cycling to night mode. He says it very easily, without looking up from whatever he's doing, and that ease has started to feel less like confidence and more like rehearsal.

I dream about the lower floors. Not dramatically, no monsters, no chases, nothing that wakes me shaking. Just long, slow dreams in which I descend a stairwell that goes much farther than it should, past floors numbered in sequences that don't match anything I know, the

fluorescent lights growing further apart the deeper I go, until there's only one light very far below, and I'm moving toward it the way you move toward a light in a dream, not quite deciding to, not quite stopping.

I've never reached the light. I always wake before that.

Sometimes I think the Tower is keeping the world outside from getting in.

Sometimes I think the Tower is keeping us from getting out.

These feel like opposite fears, but lately I've started to wonder if they're the same one. If what's being protected, the thing at the center of all this careful, persistent, ordinary-seeming silence, is not us.

If we are not the ones who need protecting.

And if whatever waits below, patient, old, quiet in the way deep things are quiet, has been waiting specifically. Not for anyone. For us. For the people in this building, in this Tower, on these numbered floors.

For us by name.

I don't know how I know that. I just know that when I press my hand flat against the floor in the dark, the way I used to press it against that library wall, I can feel something. Not sound. Not vibration, exactly. Something older than both of those.

Something that feels, terribly, like recognition.

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